Citing the pledge made by controllers never to strike, I said that if they did not return to work within forty-eight hours, their jobs would be terminated. I didn't like disrupting the lives and careers of these professionals, many of whom had spent years serving their country. I don't like firing anybody. But I realized that if they made the decision not to return to work in the full knowledge of what I'd said, then I wasn't firing them, they were giving up their jobs based on their individual decisions.

I think that members of PATCO were poorly served by their leaders. They apparently thought I was bluffing or playing games when I said controllers who didn't honor the no-strike pledge would lose their jobs and not be rehired; and I think they underestimated the courage and energy of those controllers who decided not to go on strike. The airlines and these hard-working FAA employees, as well as the traveling public, went through a difficult period. But as each day passed, there were more planes in the air; we discovered that before the strike, the air traffic control system had about six thousand more controllers than it really needed to operate safely.

Training a new crop of controllers to replace those who chose not to return would take more than two years, but our air traffic control system emerged safer and more efficient than ever.

I didn't think of it in such terms at the time, but I suppose the strike was an important juncture for our new administration. I think it convinced people who might have thought otherwise that I meant what I said. Incidentally, I would have been just as forceful if I thought management had been wrong in that dispute.